



Port of Ostia

This great trading seaport lay at the mouth of the Tiber, close to Rome. Large merchant vessels unloaded goods onto barges to continue their journey into the city itself.



Mosaic

Wealthy Romans enjoyed fine interiors in their homes, such as this late-3rd-century mosaic from a villa in Sicily.

places such as markets, public “forum” areas, bath houses, and even communal toilets were

Hypocaust remains

These remains in a bathhouse reveal the Roman underfloor heating system (*hypocaust*). The floor, now gone, was raised by short pillars around which furnace-heated air circulated.



freedoms at all, were essential for keeping the wheels of Roman life running smoothly. In the country, up to a third of the population were slaves carrying out agricultural work to supply the towns and cities.

Housing took many different forms. The wealthy lived in magnificent villas with toilets, running water, and central heating. Often centered on a cool inner courtyard, these were filled with statues and artifacts (see pp.116–17) and decorated with beautiful mosaic floors and wall-paintings showing skill in the art of perspective—famous examples survive at Pompeii and in Rome itself, such as the House of Livia. These great houses were often designed

and decorated by Greek artists living in these Roman cities. Such villas were the sites of lavish dinner parties. Food and drink was consumed on an excessive scale that has become legendary, and was accompanied by music and dancing.

Many poorer townspeople lived in crowded basic apartment blocks known as *insulae*. Remains of these buildings show similarities to modern apartment buildings, with uniform entrances and windows. The inhabitants of the *insulae* shared public toilet facilities.

Business, pleasure, and worship

Gathering for business or pleasure was a central part of Roman life. Meeting

popular spots, with private squalor offset by public grandeur. Meetings were often conducted outside, in open places, to discourage the secret plotting that characterized Roman rule.

Entertainment was also enjoyed in public arenas and theaters. This took the form of athletic games, gladiatorial combat, animal hunts, chariot races, plays and public execution of criminals. In the early centuries, the Romans of the empire believed in a range of gods and goddesses (see pp.142–43), both state and “household,” to whom they built temples. For a long time these beliefs existed alongside the rising tide of Christianity (see pp.144–45).

Laws of the land

Augustus made some legal reforms, but the basic tenets of Roman law remained. Augustus had final say in determining if a law should be passed. Citizens charged with crimes often had patrons to defend them, and criminal law was administered by Roman magistrates. Punishments were harsh. By the first half of the 2nd century CE, Roman citizens pleading a miscarriage of justice were entitled to appeal to a higher court based in the city of Rome.

A variety of factors has been blamed for triggering the gradual demise of the empire.

ANTONINE PLAGUE

Around 165 CE, a plague (possibly smallpox), broke out in the empire and lasted for around 15 years. Huge numbers lost their lives—including two emperors. One consequence was a weakening of the social fabric of the empire.

5 MILLION The number of people estimated to have died of plague in the 2nd century CE.

476 Year the Roman Empire ended in the West.

THIRD-CENTURY CRISIS

The years from 235 to 284 CE were a chaotic time, with a **rapid succession of emperors** murdered one after the other. A variety of problems beset certain parts of the empire, including starvation, plague, inflation, high taxation, and “barbarian” attacks. Some regions, such as Gaul (France) and Britain, started to assert their own interests and threaten imperial authority. Such chaos made it easier for others to seize control, such as **Queen Zenobia** of Palmyra (modern Syria) in 272–73 CE.



DIOCLETIAN EDICT

FOUR EMPERORS

In 284 CE, the period of crisis in the 3rd century ended when Roman general **Diocletian** made himself emperor. He created the first imperial college of **four emperors** (the Tetrarchy) to oversee four sections of the empire. Diocletian issued an edict in 301 to attempt to stabilize the empire's economy. The second Tetrarchy broke down and partly prefigures the empire's later permanent split into east and west in 395 CE.



MOSAIC FROM CONSTANTINOPLE

A SECOND ROME

In the early part of the 4th century CE, Roman emperor Constantine (280–337 CE) established a “second Rome” at Byzantium (modern Istanbul), renaming it Constantinople—a possible further cause of the empire's demise.



Grooming kit

Wealthy Romans were well-groomed. This is a pocket set of tweezers, nail cleaner, and ear-scoop.

Gold coins

These coins, left in Kent, England, after the Roman invasion, represent over four years' pay for a Roman legionary. The owner may have intended to collect them in more settled times.

Silver ladle and spoon

Roman silverware came in various styles and showed great technical mastery.

Samian ware bowl

Bright red “Samian” pottery, known for its distinctive red coloring, was used widely during the early imperial period.

Gold bracelet

Snake-shaped bracelets were popular. This one dates from 1st-century CE Pompeii.